system (RATO) for military aircraft. This would help our warplanes to take off from short runways in the Himalayas. Hot coffee was served over smal talk. It was total y uncharacteristic of Prof. Sarabhai. But as soon as we finished the coffee, Prof. Sarabhai rose and asked us to accompany him to Tilpat Range on the outskirts of Delhi. As we were passing through the lobby, I threw a cursory glance at the sofa where I had left the book. It was not there. It was about an hour's drive to the Range. Prof. Sarabhai showed us a Russian RATO. "If I get you the motors of this system from Russia, could you do it in eighteen months time?" Prof. Sarabhai asked us. "Yes, we can!" Both Gp Capt VS Narayanan and I spoke almost simultaneously. Prof. Sarabhai's face beamed, reflecting our fascination. I recal ed what I had read, "He wil bestow on you a light to walk in."

After dropping us back at the Hotel Ashoka, Prof. Sarabhai went to the Prime Minister's house for a breakfast meeting. By that evening, the news of India taking up the indigenous development of a device to help short run take-offs by high performance military aircraft, with myself heading the project, was made public. I was fil ed with many